

Eclipse

Rules of play

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1 Overview

Eclipse is a game of intrigue and role playing, in which players gather information to determine who their enemies are, and gather items to defeat their enemies.

The game is primarily designed to be played with 4 players. It can also support 6 or 8 players, although these are not as well tested. There is also a cooperative mode where players fight against the zombie horde. This mode is primarily designed for 3 players, but also supports more or fewer.

1.1 Quick intro for standard 4 player game

Each player will be dealt a hidden faction card. The faction cards are Marked Sun, Unmarked Sun, Marked Moon, and Unmarked Moon. The players with Sun cards are on a team against the players with the Moon cards. The Marked/Unmarked status is also important - the Sun players must mortally wound the Marked player first, or lose the game immediately.

Players take turns moving around to different locations, drawing Tavern cards and acquiring Items. Tavern cards work as follows: each Tavern card is formulated as a yes/no question. When a location, such as the “Tavern” instructs player A to draw a Tavern card, player A draws the Tavern card, reads it silently, and does NOT answer the question. They then pass the card, face down, to another player B of their choice. That player then answers verbally, with “Yes” or “No.” This exchange gives information to player A about player B’s faction card, but not to any other player.

Information gathering is important in order to determine teams, but the Marked/Unmarked status is also important to know. As mentioned, if the Sun team mortally wounds the Unmarked Moon player before the Marked Moon player, the Moon team wins.

The rest of the gameplay is much less complicated. The early turns are usually spent drawing Tavern cards to gain information, and then the game transitions to a race to deal damage to the enemy team by acquiring items and attacking.

One aspect which is not common to other games is that damage is counted *up* in Eclipse. Players start at zero damage, and advance up along the damage track as they take damage. This is primarily because players have variable maximum health, determined by adding the numbers on the character and power cards.

2 Game pieces

2.1 Cards

There are several types of cards.

- *Faction* - orange color. These assign hidden roles and teams to players.
- *Character* - red color. These give passive abilities to players, and include a number for max health.
- *Power* - dark blue color. These give a one-time ability to players, and include a number for max health. A player can use their power card once per game.
- *Location* - purple color. These form the board of play.
- *Item* - black color. Players acquire these randomly. They may increase attack power, ability to choose where one moves, or a variety of other things.
- *Tavern* - green color. These give players information about other players' factions.
- *Token* - light blue color. These do various things.
- *Zombie* - teal color. These are only used for the cooperative zombie horde mode.

2.2 Other

- *Dice* - 6 sided dice. Assorted other dice are useful for tracking counters on cards.
- *Number chips* - 6 distinct chips, labelled 1,2,3,4,5,6. These go on locations.
- *Player tokens* - sets of three small cubes of the same color in a variety of colors.
- *Number tracks* - number track for player damage, and tracking other things.

3 Gameplay

3.1 Set up

First time playing setup - Use the following location cards: Market, Tavern, Armory, Cursed Shrine, Potion Shop, and Junkyard. If you want a straightforward game, remove the following cards for the first game - Kraken (character), Betray (power), Recant (power), Unmask (power), Hoarded Secrets (power), Defect (power).

Not first time - If not playing for the first time, choose locations as follows: always use one tavern, one armory, and one market location, and 3 locations which are not market, tavern, or armory type.

1. Set locations in the middle of the playing area in three pairs of two each, in a circle. Place one number chip on each location, at random.
2. Follow any “During setup...” instructions on locations.
3. Choose faction cards to use. For a game with $2n$ players, there should be n Moon cards, one of which is marked, and n Sun cards, one of which is marked.
4. Deal each player one faction, character, and power card (all face down).
5. Randomly choose a player to go first.

3.2 Sequence of play

Players take turns clockwise around the table. On their turn, a player takes the following actions. At any point during these actions, a player can use the effect of a character, power, or item card. Note that players can use such effects on other players turns, not only their own.

1. Roll two D6, then move to a location with either of those numbers. You cannot move to your current location; if you roll your current location on one die, then you can only move to the other location. If you roll your current location on both dice, you can choose anywhere to move.
2. Perform the effect on the location, excluding “During setup, ...”. For example, if a player moves to the Tavern location, they heal one damage, and draw a Tavern card.
3. Attack another player in the same area. This is optional. Each pair of two locations forms an “area.” Players can attack other players in the same area. Attacking another player deals them 2 damage.

A player’s maximum health is the sum of the numbers on their power and character cards. When a player has taken damage greater than or equal to their maximum health, they become mortally wounded. Mortally wounded players cannot use their character or power

cards, but may otherwise retain items and take turns as normal.

A player can use the effect of their character throughout the game. They can only use the effect of their power card once during the game.

3.3 Ending the game

The game ends when any one player has taken damage equal to their max HP. The opposing team wins, with one exception: if damage caused by the opposing team causes an Unmarked player to take lethal damage, then the team whose player died wins the game.

If a Marked player would take lethal damage, a player of the same faction may choose to take the excess damage instead. This can only happen if both players' faction cards are face up. The damage is divided up so that the Marked player takes damage until their remaining HP is 1. The remaining damage is dealt to the Unmarked player of the same faction. (This damage is considered to be dealt by the Unmarked player to themselves, so if the Unmarked player would take lethal damage using this redirection, they don't win due to the "Unmarked death rule.")

3.4 Glossary

Area - A pair of two adjacent locations.

Attack range - The collection of locations which a given player can attack. The default attack range is just the player's current area, but may be increase or decreased by the effects of Items, Characters, Powers, or Tokens.

Heal - Move the players damage counter down that amount on the damage track. A player cannot heal below zero damage.

Location - A single location card where a player token can be.

Maximum health - The sum of the numbers on a players character and power cards.

Mortally wounded - A player who has taken damage equal to or greater than their maximum health. Mortally wounded players cannot use their character or power cards.

3.5 FAQ

3.5.1 General

Can a player heal if they have zero damage? No.

What is a Portable Portal, and what does it do? A Portable Portal is a card from the token deck. After a player has rolled dice to move, they may decide to discard a Portable

Portal to treat that roll if it were anything of their choice.

What happens when an attack is cancelled? Anything that says “When you attack ...” still happens if the attack is cancelled, but things which say “After you attack ...” do not happen. For example, if a player attacks with the Sword of Truth item, the effect still resolves, but if the Samurai attacks and the attack is cancelled, the Samurai does not get a counter.

3.5.2 Locations

What is the difference between “before rolling” and “when rolling” to move? Some effects, like Portable Portals and the Pet Wolf item, can be used by a player to make a decision about moving after having seen their roll to move. Other effects, such as the Market Town or Poor Man’s Tavern location, require a player to make a decision before rolling. That is, if a player has already rolled dice to move, they cannot retroactively choose to move to the Market Town if their roll does not allow that.

What happens if the Dragon’s Hoard runs out? Nothing, you don’t refill it. If you move there, you get no items.

What does the Gladiator Arena do? If a player is at the Gladiator Arena and makes an attack, the attack deals +3 damage. If this happens 5 times, then the game changes from a team game to free-for-all. Mortally wounded players no longer continue to take turns, and instead leave the game.

What if I have 4 Royalty counters from Throne Room and another player also has 5, but we don’t know if we are on the same team? One of you may choose to reveal their faction card to determine if you are on the same team, but otherwise nothing happens. You have to be confirm in order to win the game.

What do we do if a player has taken a lot of damage but still doesn’t know their own maximum health due to Midnight Market or Souk? If a player has taken more than 12 or so damage, have the player reveal their unknown character or power card to other players, in order to determine if they are mortally wounded.

What happens when a player is moved to a location by an effect other than rolling? Nothing. For example, if a players token is moved by the effect of the Maelstrom or Out of the Mist power, or the Sorceress character, the player does not get to use the location effect.

3.5.3 Characters

Does it count as being healed for the Hag if I have zero damage? No, if you have zero damage and would be healed, nothing happens so the Hag cannot deal damage.

3.5.4 Items

What can Mana Potion add counters to? It can add counters to things like the Cannon or Investment items, or Samurai or Hydra characters. It cannot add Royalty counters to players, since those are not counters on a card.

4 Cooperative mode

4.1 Overview

This section details rules relating to the cooperative version of Eclipse where players all work together to overcome the zombie horde. Throughout the game, zombies will be summoned from the zombie deck, and move around to various locations. The players win the game collectively when 20 zombies have died.

To **summon** a zombie means the following: draw a zombie card from the zombie deck, then roll a D6. Place the zombie card at that location.

A zombie card has three attributes: text, attack, and health. The attack is the left number in the bottom right corner, and the health is the right number. The health is how much damage the zombie can take before dying and being removed from the board. The attack is how much damage the zombie attacks any players for when it moves to a new location.

4.2 Setup

1. When choosing locations, always use the “Graveyard” location instead of a tavern location.
2. Remove cards from the character, power, item, and location deck which interact with tavern cards or gaining of information, since that aspect of the game is removed in this mode. For example, the “Imp,” “Kraken,” “Inquisitor” characters should be removed, among others.
3. Set up other locations, characters, and powers as usual. There is no need to deal faction cards.
4. Before the first players turn, summon one zombie per player, plus 3. For example, in a 3 player game, start the game by summoning 6 zombies.
5. Place a marker at the first spot on the spawn rate track.

4.3 Sequence of play

Players take their turns as normal. They can attack and damage zombies (e.g. using items) as if zombies were players. For example, if a player has the “Magical Bolt” item, they can discard it to deal 3 damage to a zombie. After each player turn, the zombie horde takes a turn. On the zombie horde’s turn, the following actions happen in this order.

1. Each zombie on the board moves one location clockwise.
2. Each zombie that moved to a location which contains a player attacks that player. If there are two players at a location and a zombie moves to that location, the zombie attacks both players.
3. Summon new zombies equal to the current spawn rate. (The spawn rate starts at 1.)

4. Advance the spawn track by one.

Whenever a zombie is killed, remove it from the board and add it to a stack which tracks how many zombie haves been killed, and advance the spawn track by one. Players win when 20 zombies have died.

4.4 Adjusting difficulty

If players find the zombie horde too difficult or too easy, they can easily tinker with the difficulty setting by tweaking the following numbers: the number of zombies summoned at the start of the game, or the starting place of the spawn rate track. I have not tested the mode much outside of a 3 player game, so other numbers of players may be harder or easier. The 3 player version is eminently winnable with the numbers described above, assuming the players don't all have very weak characters for it.